

Chapter 65: Dialect, Identity, and Authenticity in Contemporary Telugu Cinema: A Sociolinguistic Analysis

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Abstract

Post-2014 Telugu cinema has experienced a profound linguistic paradigm shift, systematically dismantling historical hierarchies that long privileged standardized registers over regional vernaculars. This study investigates the sociolinguistic depiction of Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra dialects in contemporary Tollywood, exploring how language variation indexes identity, power, authenticity, and socio-economic status. Utilizing a qualitative framework that synthesizes variationist sociolinguistics with critical discourse analysis, researchers examine six seminal films: Arjun Reddy (2017), Rangasthalam (2018), Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo (2020), Pushpa: The Rise (2021), Balagam (2023), and Dasara (2023). The findings illuminate a significant revaluation of regional speech: Telangana dialects have transitioned from marginalized comic tropes to narrative centers; Rayalaseema vernacular has been progressively decoupled from factionalist stereotypes; and Coastal Andhra speech continues to command prestige while simultaneously accommodating localized, rural subjectivities. Ultimately, this chapter contends that contemporary Telugu cinema operates as a critical cultural site where linguistic hegemony is actively reproduced, contested, and reconfigured

Keywords: Telugu Cinema, Sociolinguistics, Dialects, Language Variation, Identity, Tollywood

1. Introduction

Language variation functions as a powerful social resource through which identities, regional affiliations, and power relations are dynamically communicated. As foundational sociolinguistic scholarship establishes, speech varieties acquire prestige or stigma not through inherent linguistic characteristics, but through structured social processes (Labov, 1972; Wardhaugh & Fuller, 2021). Within this dynamic, mass media operates as a critical apparatus; cinematic discourse does not merely reflect existing speech patterns but actively assigns symbolic meanings to specific registers, thereby shaping public perceptions of language and social hierarchy (Sundar, 2016; Sreebitha, 2019). Historically, mainstream Telugu cinema institutionalized Coastal Andhra speech as the unmarked, hegemonically naturalized standard—an auditory shorthand consistently associated with formal education, administrative authority, and socio-economic refinement (Phani Pooja & Sarma, 2016). Conversely, regional speech communities faced systematic screen marginalization. Telangana dialects were routinely restricted to caricature, low-status comic roles, or depictions of pastoral simplicity, while Rayalaseema speech was strictly pigeonholed into narratives of hyper-masculine assertion, patriarchal dominance and factional violence.

This long-standing linguistic hierarchy underwent a seismic shift following the political bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014 and the subsequent formation of Telangana. This socio-political turning point fundamentally reconfigured Telugu cultural production, catalyzing a transition "from resistance to recognition" in the construction of regional identity (Putta & Gosikonda, 2023). The political decentralization of the region coincided with an artistic emergence of regionally rooted, vernacular

narratives that aggressively foregrounded localized linguistic practices. Landmark films such as *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021), *Balagam* (2023), and *Dasara* (2023) shattered industry conventions by demonstrating that strongly localized, historically stigmatized dialects could achieve immense commercial success, pan-Indian market viability, and high cultural prestige (Sammata, 2025). Consequently, contemporary Telugu cinema increasingly deploys regional dialects not merely as passive markers of geography, but as intentional, strategic tools for constructing authenticity, community solidarity, and localized resistance. Recent cinematic texts indicate a profound, ongoing reconfiguration of traditional linguistic hierarchies, rendering Tollywood a vital site where historical language ideologies are actively interrogated, contested, and rewritten.

Research Objectives

This study aims to:

1. Identify the major Telugu dialects represented in contemporary cinema.
2. Examine how dialects contribute to character construction and narrative development.
3. Analyze the relationship between dialect choice and representations of power, prestige, and identity.
4. Investigate how contemporary films challenge or reinforce linguistic stereotypes.
5. Explore the role of dialects in generating authenticity and audience engagement.

Research Questions

1. Which Telugu dialects dominate contemporary cinema?
2. How are dialects used to construct character identities?
3. What sociolinguistic meanings are associated with different regional varieties?
4. How do films challenge or reproduce linguistic stereotypes?
5. How do dialect representations influence audience perceptions of authenticity and belonging?

2. Literature Review

The theoretical architecture of variationist sociolinguistics posits that language varieties operate not merely as neutral instruments of communication, but as primary signifiers of social identity, alignment, and group membership (Labov, 1972; Holmes, 2013; Wardhaugh & Fuller, 2021). A foundational axiom of this discipline is that dialects acquire social evaluation—namely prestige or stigma—through external socio-political and structural processes rather than any inherent linguistic superiority or defect (Labov, 1972; Wardhaugh & Fuller, 2021). Within the domain of Telugu dialectology, empirical scholarship by Sastry (1987) and Shivaprasad and Sadanandam (2020) has meticulously mapped this terrain, demonstrating the existence of structurally distinct regional phonological, intonational, and lexical systems across the geographical territories of Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra. Parallel insights from media and cultural studies confirm that linguistic choices within film and television are never ideologically neutral. Cinematic discourse functions as a potent semiotic site that actively constructs, reproduces, and naturalizes social categories through targeted linguistic representation (Sundar, 2016; Sreebitha, 2019). Within Telugu media history, onscreen language use has strictly mirrored existing societal power structures and prestige hierarchies, consistently reinforcing elite dominance by elevating particular speech patterns while marginalizing others (Phani Pooja & Sarma, 2016).

Furthermore, contemporary linguistic scholarship has increasingly turned its focus toward the phenomenon of linguistic hybridity within rapidly expanding urban spaces. English–Telugu code-mixing and code-switching have emerged as defining characteristics of modern everyday communication (Vaish, 2013; Naik, 2024). In the context of media representation, these hybrid registers are frequently leveraged as an acoustic index for formal education, upward mobility, and cosmopolitan modernity (Vaish, 2013; Naik, 2024). Krishna (2021) notes that these specific linguistic choices, particularly when capturing metropolitan spaces like Hyderabad, critically expose the structural frictions and ongoing cultural negotiations occurring between globalizing forces and regional identities. Despite these valuable standalone contributions from sociolinguistics, media studies, and urban geography, a significant gap persists in current academic literature. To date, very little comparative research has examined how the three major Telugu regional dialects function simultaneously, interactively, and contrastively within the landscape of contemporary cinema. This study directly addresses this empirical and theoretical omission. By conducting a systematic comparative analysis, this research investigates the evolving, multi-layered sociolinguistic meanings attached to Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra speech registers in post-2014 Telugu films.

3. Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative, interpretive research design that synthesizes content analysis with critical discourse analysis (CDA). Methodologically, rather than relying on quantitative frequency counts of specific words, this research prioritizes a deep hermeneutic examination of how dialects function as dynamic symbolic resources used to construct identity, authority, authenticity, and social belonging within cinematic spaces. By treating film dialogue as a form of social practice, this approach uncovers the underlying power structures and language ideologies embedded within the texts.

3.1 Sampling Strategy

A purposive sample of six feature films was selected from the post-2014 era of Telugu cinema. These specific texts were chosen due to their intense linguistic orientation, immense box-office footprint, and undeniable cultural significance within the contemporary public sphere:

- *Arjun Reddy* (2017): Critical for evaluating urban bilingualism and cosmopolitan identity markers.
- *Rangasthalam* (2018): Chosen for its hyper-localized exploration of rural Coastal Andhra speech dynamics.
- *Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo* (2020): Selected as a representative benchmark for the standard, elite prestige register.
- *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021): Vital for analyzing the modern subversion of sub-regional border dialects and working-class mobility.
- *Balagam* (2023): Essential for assessing the reclamation of rural Telangana registers for emotional depth and communal intimacy.
- *Dasara* (2023): Included to examine the intersection of working-class resistance, labor, and localized Telangana speech.

3.2 Data Categorization

The analytical matrix targets three distinct categories of linguistic data extracted from the film scripts and character interactions:

- **Regional Lexical and Syntactic Markers:** The deployment of localized vocabulary, unique idioms, and distinct grammatical syntax that firmly root a character within a specific regional landscape.
- **Phonological and Intonational Variation:** Sound patterns, phonetic accents, and unique vocal inflections that aurally signal regional alignment, class background, or emotional states.
- **English–Telugu Code-Mixing and Code-Switching:** The structural mixing of English and Telugu words within a single utterance, or switching between languages altogether, used to index education, class mobility, and urban cosmopolitanism.

3.3 Theoretical Synthesis

The operational framework blends variationist sociolinguistics with critical discourse analysis (CDA). Variationist sociolinguistics provides the tools to trace how fine-grained linguistic variations map onto social categories (Labov, 1972). Concurrently, CDA unpacks how these linguistic forms acquire complex social meanings, revealing the ways in which everyday speech acts are intentionally leveraged within cinematic narratives to either challenge or reinforce dominant cultural hegemonies. This dual approach ensures that the linguistic data is always interpreted through a lens of social power and cultural politics.

4. Discussion

4.1 Telangana Dialect: From Marginalization to Authenticity

Perhaps the most significant linguistic transformation in contemporary Telugu cinema is the revaluation of the Telangana dialect. Historically, Telangana speech was frequently relegated to comic roles and represented as a marker of rural simplicity, limited education, or social marginality. Such portrayals reinforced linguistic hierarchies in which standardized Telugu occupied the position of prestige, while regional varieties were often stigmatized (Phani Pooja & Sarma, 2016; Krishna, 2021). In the post-2014 cinematic landscape, however, Telangana speech has increasingly emerged as a legitimate and prestigious medium for expressing identity, emotion, and cultural authenticity. A notable example is *Balagam* (2023), where the Telangana dialect functions as a vehicle of communal memory and emotional depth rather than comic entertainment. Expressions such as “*Endira bidda?*” (“What is it, child?”) (Venu Yeldandi, 2023) and “*Mana oorollu andharu ikkade unnaru*” (“All our villagers are here”) (Venu Yeldandi, 2023) foreground kinship, collective belonging, and interpersonal intimacy. The use of culturally embedded lexical items such as *bidda* and *oorollu* situates the narrative firmly within the sociocultural realities of rural Telangana. Through everyday conversations surrounding family relationships, mourning rituals, and village life, the film transforms the dialect into a repository of local values and shared cultural experience. As Putta and Gosikonda (2023) argue, contemporary Telangana cinema increasingly employs regional speech as a symbol of cultural pride and collective identity rather than social inferiority.

A similar linguistic orientation is evident in *Dasara* (2023), where Telangana speech is embedded within the socio-economic realities of a working-class mining community. Dialogues such as “*Idhi mana batuku*” (“This is our life”) (Srikanth Odela, 2023) and recurring references to “*Maa ooru*” (“Our village”) (Srikanth Odela, 2023) emphasize solidarity, resilience, and a shared sense of struggle. Rather than portraying the dialect as linguistically deficient, the film associates it with dignity, resistance, and

emotional authenticity. The vernacular speech patterns employed by the characters create a sense of realism that aligns with contemporary audience expectations for culturally grounded narratives. In this context, language becomes an index of lived experience, connecting regional identity with labour, community, and social belonging. The representation of Telangana identity in *Arjun Reddy* (2017) introduces a different sociolinguistic dimension. Set within the urban environment of Hyderabad, the film reflects the multilingual realities of educated metropolitan youth through extensive Telugu-English code-mixing. Expressions such as “*I am a surgeon*”, “*basic understanding*”, and “*Don’t act smart*” (Vanga S.R., 2017) are seamlessly interwoven with Telugu discourse, reflecting the linguistic practices of urban professionals. Rather than relying on traditional rural dialect markers, the film constructs Telangana identity through cosmopolitan multilingualism and linguistic hybridity. Such language practices correspond to broader patterns of urban communication identified by Vasanta et al. (2010) and Naik (2024), where code-mixing functions as a marker of education, professional status, and modernity.

Taken together, *Balagam*, *Dasara*, and *Arjun Reddy* illustrate the expanding sociolinguistic space occupied by Telangana speech in contemporary Telugu cinema. The dialect is no longer confined to caricatured or peripheral characters; instead, it appears across rural, working-class, and elite urban settings. This shift reflects a broader ideological transformation in which Telangana speech has moved from the margins of cinematic representation to become a powerful symbol of authenticity, cultural pride, and regional identity. The growing acceptance of dialect-rich narratives demonstrates how contemporary Telugu cinema has begun to challenge earlier linguistic prejudices and redefine the cultural value of regional speech varieties (Krishna, 2021; Putta & Gosikonda, 2023).

4.2 Rayalaseema Dialect: Beyond Factional Stereotypes

Among the major regional varieties represented in Telugu cinema, the Rayalaseema dialect has historically carried some of the strongest ideological associations. For decades, mainstream films frequently linked Rayalaseema speech with factional violence, patriarchal authority, and rural power structures, creating a cinematic shorthand through which linguistic features were used to signal aggression, dominance, and moral rigidity. As a result, a linguistically diverse speech community was often reduced to a narrow set of stereotypical character traits, reinforcing the association between regional identity and violence.

Traditional cinematic representations frequently employed dialogues such as “*Mata ichchaanante ichchaanu*” (“Once I give my word, I stand by it”) and “*Pranam poyina parledhu, maata tappakudadhu*” (“Life may be lost, but one’s word should never be broken”). Whereas, These dialogues demonstrate how older mainstream films used assertive syntax and emphatic speech patterns to construct the hyper-masculine, morally rigid identity of Rayalaseema feudal heroes or faction leaders (seen in classic movies like *Samarasimha Reddy*, *Narasimha Naidu*, *Indra*, or *Aadi*). These expressions reflect a discourse of honour, loyalty, and personal integrity that has become closely associated with Rayalaseema identity in popular culture. Linguistically, such utterances rely on direct, assertive syntax and emphatic speech patterns that index determination, authority, and social power. Within cinematic narratives, these linguistic features often function as symbolic markers of masculinity and territorial control, reinforcing the image of the Rayalaseema male as uncompromising and emotionally restrained. However, contemporary Telugu cinema has begun to complicate this long-standing stereotype. A significant example is *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021), which reconfigures the sociolinguistic meaning of Rayalaseema

speech by placing a strongly localized Chittoor-border vernacular in the speech of a working-class protagonist rather than a faction leader or feudal strongman. Through dialogues such as “*Pushpa ante flower anukuntiva? Fire-u!*” (“Do you think Pushpa means a flower? It means fire!”) (Sukumar, 2021) and the widely popular catchphrase “*Ni yavva thaggedhe le*” (“No backing down”) (Sukumar, 2021), the film transforms regional speech into a language of aspiration, resistance, and self-assertion. The incorporation of English lexical elements such as *flower* and *fire* alongside localized Telugu forms creates a hybrid linguistic register that reflects contemporary social mobility while retaining strong regional identity.

Importantly, the protagonist's dialect is not presented as a marker of backwardness or criminality. Instead, it becomes a source of symbolic strength and cultural authenticity. Pushpa's speech reflects the experiences of a marginalized laboring class struggling for economic advancement and social recognition. In this context, the dialect functions as an index of resilience and ambition rather than inherited power. The film therefore challenges the conventional equation between Rayalaseema speech and violence by demonstrating that the same linguistic variety can also represent perseverance, dignity, and social transformation. Nevertheless, traces of earlier linguistic ideologies remain visible. Contemporary representations continue to associate Rayalaseema speech with toughness, physical courage, and hyper-masculine identity. While the dialect is no longer exclusively tied to factional conflict, it is often framed through narratives of struggle, endurance, and confrontation. Thus, contemporary Telugu cinema has not entirely abandoned earlier stereotypes; rather, it has reconfigured them. The Rayalaseema dialect now occupies a more complex sociolinguistic position, functioning simultaneously as a marker of regional pride, subaltern resilience, masculine authority, and cultural authenticity. This transformation illustrates how cinematic language both reflects and reshapes evolving perceptions of regional identity in contemporary Telugu society.

4.3 Coastal Andhra Dialect: Prestige, Standardization, and Regional Diversity

Among the major Telugu dialect groups, the Coastal Andhra variety has historically occupied the most privileged position within Telugu cinema. Due to its close association with education, administration, print media, and urban professional life, this variety gradually became institutionalized as “Standard Telugu.” Unlike other regional dialects that were frequently marked as rural, comic, or regionally specific, Coastal Andhra speech was often presented as linguistically neutral and socially desirable. Consequently, standard Telugu acquired symbolic prestige and functioned as the default language of authority, refinement, and upward social mobility (Phani Pooja & Sarma, 2016; Holmes, 2013).

This prestige orientation is clearly evident in *Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo* (2020), where characters predominantly employ grammatically refined Telugu with minimal regional marking. Dialogues such as “*Matallo depth thaggindi, kani andam pergindi*” (“The depth in your words has decreased, but the beauty has increased”) (Trivikram, 2020) reflect a carefully structured linguistic style characterized by lexical sophistication and controlled delivery. The absence of noticeable regional features itself becomes sociolinguistically significant. Rather than drawing attention to a specific geographical identity, the language projects education, corporate competence, and social privilege. Within the film's urban setting, standard Telugu functions as a linguistic resource that indexes professionalism, cultural capital, and access to elite social spaces. As a result, the dialect reinforces long-standing associations between standard speech and institutional authority. At the same time, contemporary Telugu cinema has begun to

complicate the notion of a singular Coastal Andhra identity. A significant example is *Rangasthalam* (2018), which foregrounds localized Godavari-region speech patterns and rural cultural practices. Through dialogues such as “*Mana ooriki mana maatale gauravam*” (“Our village's pride lies in our own speech”) (Sukumar, 2018) and the extensive use of region-specific vocabulary, the film highlights linguistic features that are often absent from standardized cinematic Telugu. The narrative situates language within everyday village life, emphasizing local customs, kinship networks, and community relationships. Rather than presenting rural speech as linguistically inferior, the film validates regional variation as an authentic expression of cultural identity.

The sociolinguistic significance of *Rangasthalam* lies in its challenge to standard-language ideology. By centering a rural community and employing localized vernacular forms throughout the narrative, the film demonstrates that linguistic legitimacy is not restricted to standardized speech. Instead, regional dialects emerge as important carriers of memory, tradition, and collective identity. This shift broadens cinematic representations of Coastal Andhra beyond the urban-professional stereotype that historically dominated mainstream Telugu cinema. Nevertheless, the prestige associated with standard Telugu remains influential. Contemporary films continue to associate accent-neutral speech with education, corporate success, and administrative authority. However, recent narratives increasingly acknowledge the internal diversity of Coastal Andhra by incorporating localized dialects and rural speech practices into mainstream storytelling. Consequently, the Coastal Andhra variety now occupies a dual sociolinguistic position within Telugu cinema: it functions both as the language of institutional prestige and as a source of regional authenticity. This development reflects a broader transformation in contemporary Telugu cinema, where linguistic diversity is increasingly recognized as a valuable cultural resource rather than a deviation from a standardized norm.

4.4 Dialect and Character Identity

Dialect functions as a powerful semiotic resource in character construction within contemporary Telugu cinema. Beyond serving as a marker of geographical origin, speech varieties communicate social status, educational background, occupational identity, and moral positioning. Historically, Telugu cinema relied on relatively rigid linguistic conventions in which protagonists predominantly spoke standardized Telugu, villains were frequently associated with Rayalaseema factional registers, and Telangana dialects were often reserved for comic or subordinate characters. Through these recurring patterns, language became a shorthand for assigning social value and narrative significance to characters. Traditional heroic characters were commonly represented through accent-neutral standardized Telugu, which symbolized education, refinement, and institutional authority. This linguistic norm positioned standard Telugu as the natural language of leadership and social prestige. In contrast, regional dialects were frequently restricted to peripheral roles, reinforcing hierarchical distinctions between standard and non-standard varieties. Similarly, cinematic villains often employed forceful Rayalaseema speech characterized by expressions such as “*Mata ichchaanante ichchaanu*” and “*Pranam poyina parledhu, maata tappakudadhu,*” linking regional identity with aggression, patriarchal authority, and factional power. Telangana speech, meanwhile, was regularly assigned to comic characters whose humour derived from exaggerated pronunciation, lexical choices, or perceived rural simplicity.

Contemporary Telugu cinema has increasingly challenged these established conventions. Films such as *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021), *Dasara* (2023), and *Balagam* (2023) place localized dialects at the centre of the

narrative by assigning them to protagonists rather than side characters. In *Pushpa*, the hero's Chittoor-border vernacular becomes a symbol of resilience and ambition, while *Dasara* and *Balagam* employ Telangana speech to express emotional depth, collective memory, and community solidarity. Dialogues such as “*Ni yavva thaggedhe le*”(Sukumar, 2021) and “*Idhi mana batuku*”(Srikanth Odela, 2023) demonstrate that contemporary heroism can be articulated through regional speech without relying on the prestige traditionally associated with standardized Telugu. The representation of supporting characters has also undergone significant transformation. Rather than functioning merely as comic relief or narrative fillers, supporting characters increasingly employ authentic regional speech patterns that enrich the sociocultural landscape of the film. Localized kinship terms, ritual expressions, and region-specific vocabulary contribute to narrative realism by grounding characters within identifiable social worlds. In films such as *Balagam* and *Rangasthalam*, supporting characters become important carriers of cultural memory and communal values, with their speech reflecting everyday linguistic practices rather than exaggerated stereotypes.

Another notable shift concerns the relationship between dialect and morality. Earlier cinematic narratives often used language as a direct indicator of moral alignment, with standard Telugu associated with virtue and authority, and heavily marked dialects linked to villainy or social deviance. Contemporary films increasingly reject this simplistic linguistic coding. Characters speaking Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra varieties now occupy diverse moral positions, allowing audiences to evaluate them based on their actions rather than their accents. Consequently, dialect functions less as a marker of inherent character traits and more as a reflection of social experience, regional identity, and cultural belonging. This transformation illustrates a broader sociolinguistic shift in Telugu cinema. Dialects are no longer confined to stereotypical roles or hierarchical linguistic categories; instead, they operate as dynamic resources through which filmmakers construct authentic, multidimensional characters. By decentralizing the dominance of standardized Telugu, contemporary cinema has expanded the representational possibilities available to regional speech communities and contributed to a more inclusive portrayal of linguistic diversity of three regions in two Telugu states.

4.5 Audience Reception and Linguistic Authenticity

Audience reception has played a crucial role in reshaping the sociolinguistic status of Telugu dialects in contemporary cinema. While filmmakers have increasingly incorporated regional speech varieties into mainstream narratives, it is audience acceptance and popular engagement that have transformed these dialects into valuable forms of cultural capital. The widespread popularity of dialect-rich films demonstrates that linguistic authenticity has become an important criterion through which viewers evaluate cinematic realism, character credibility, and emotional resonance.

The cultural impact of films such as *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021) and *Dasara* (2023) is particularly evident in the circulation of iconic dialogues beyond the cinematic screen. Special expressions and select dialogues in these films have rapidly entered public discourse, appearing in everyday conversations, social media interactions, digital memes, political rhetoric, and popular culture. The adoption of these phrases by audiences across regional boundaries illustrates how localized speech varieties can transcend their original linguistic communities and acquire broader social significance. In sociolinguistic terms, such diffusion reflects the increasing prestige and symbolic value attached to regional dialects within contemporary Telugu society.

The popularity of these expressions also signals a broader process of linguistic democratization. Historically, heavily marked regional dialects were often associated with lower social status and were less likely to be publicly embraced outside their immediate speech communities. Contemporary audiences, however, increasingly celebrate dialect-based expressions as markers of authenticity, regional pride, and cultural distinctiveness. As a result, linguistic forms that were once marginalized now function as widely recognized symbols of identity and belonging. This shift suggests that audience practices play an active role in challenging traditional language hierarchies and reshaping perceptions of linguistic legitimacy.

Furthermore, audience responses indicate a growing preference for realistic and contextually appropriate language use. Viewers increasingly expect characters to speak in ways that correspond to their geographical origins, occupations, and social environments. Films such as *Balagam*, *Dasara*, and *Rangasthalam* derive much of their emotional impact from the close alignment between language and lived experience. When regional characters employ authentic dialects, audiences often perceive the narrative as more credible and culturally grounded. Conversely, the use of highly standardized speech in localized settings may create a sense of artificiality that weakens audience engagement.

The commercial success of dialect-driven films therefore reflects more than a stylistic trend; it indicates a significant transformation in audience attitudes toward language diversity. Regional dialects have become both economically viable and culturally influential within mainstream Telugu cinema. By rewarding films that embrace linguistic authenticity, contemporary audiences have contributed to the revaluation of Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra speech varieties, encouraging filmmakers to move beyond standardized linguistic norms and engage more fully with the rich diversity of Telugu language practices.

5. Findings and Conclusion

The findings of this study reveal a substantial reconfiguration of linguistic hierarchies within contemporary Telugu cinema. The analysis demonstrates that regional dialects are no longer confined to peripheral or stereotypical roles; instead, they have emerged as central resources for constructing identity, authenticity, and cultural belonging. This transformation reflects broader shifts in language ideologies, audience expectations, and representational practices in post-2014 Telugu cinema. Among the three major dialect groups, Telangana speech has undergone the most significant sociolinguistic revaluation. Once frequently associated with comic relief, rural backwardness, and social marginality, Telangana dialects now occupy a position of narrative prominence and cultural prestige. Films such as *Balagam* (2023) and *Dasara* (2023) employ Telangana speech as a medium for articulating emotional depth, collective memory, community solidarity, and regional pride. The increasing visibility of Telangana dialects illustrates how previously marginalized linguistic forms can acquire legitimacy and symbolic value through cultural representation.

The representation of Rayalaseema speech also reflects a notable shift in cinematic discourse. While traces of earlier associations with factionalism, patriarchal authority, and hyper-masculinity remain evident, contemporary films increasingly frame the dialect through narratives of resilience, aspiration, and social mobility. *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021), for instance, repositions Rayalaseema speech as a marker of perseverance and self-assertion rather than merely an index of violence and power. This shift broadens the sociolinguistic meanings attached to the dialect and challenges long-standing cinematic stereotypes. Coastal Andhra speech continues to occupy a privileged position within Telugu cinema due to its

historical association with education, administration, and linguistic standardization. However, films such as *Rangasthalam* (2018) demonstrate a growing recognition of intra-regional diversity by foregrounding localized speech forms and rural cultural identities. Consequently, Coastal Andhra varieties now function simultaneously as symbols of institutional prestige and expressions of regional authenticity.

More broadly, the study highlights the role of language as a form of symbolic capital within cinematic discourse. Dialects serve not merely as indicators of geographical origin but as powerful semiotic resources through which class, identity, authority, social aspiration, and cultural belonging are negotiated. The findings suggest that contemporary Telugu cinema increasingly values linguistic authenticity over standard-language conformity, thereby expanding the representational possibilities available to regional speech communities. Although older stereotypes continue to persist in modified forms, contemporary Telugu cinema has significantly broadened the sociolinguistic landscape of representation. Regional dialects are now more likely to be associated with complex protagonists, emotionally nuanced narratives, and culturally grounded storytelling. This development reflects a gradual democratization of linguistic representation, whereby multiple speech varieties are afforded visibility, legitimacy, and cultural significance within mainstream cinema.

In conclusion, contemporary Telugu cinema functions as a dynamic sociolinguistic arena in which language ideologies are continually negotiated, contested, and transformed. By elevating regional dialects from the margins to the centre of cinematic storytelling, filmmakers have contributed to the redefinition of linguistic prestige and the affirmation of diverse regional identities. The evolving representation of Telangana, Rayalaseema, and Coastal Andhra speech varieties underscores the growing recognition of linguistic diversity as an essential component of cultural authenticity in contemporary Telugu society.

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